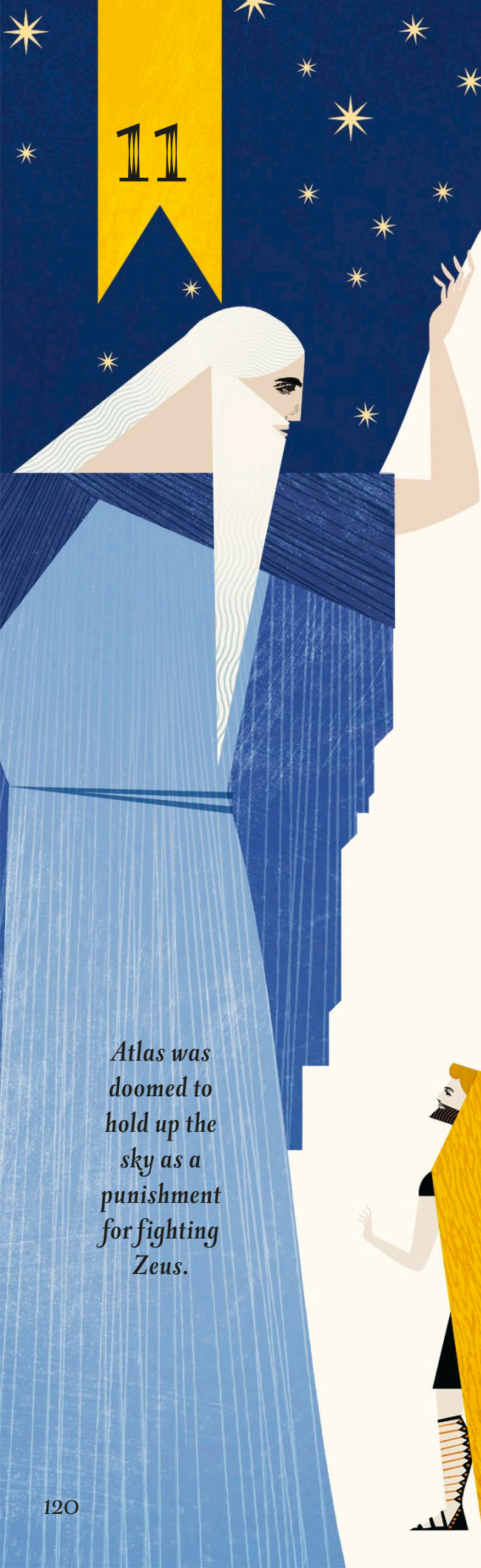


A stylized illustration of Atlas, a Titan, holding up the sky. He is depicted from the waist up, wearing a blue robe with a white sash. His long white hair flows down his back. He is looking up at the sky, which is dark blue with many yellow stars. His right arm is raised, supporting the sky. A yellow banner with the number '11' is in the top left corner.

*Atlas was doomed to hold up the sky as a punishment for fighting Zeus.*

As each of his other plans had failed, crafty Eurystheus decided for the eleventh labor to send Heracles to fetch an apple from the tree of the Hesperides. This was not an easy task. The tree had been a gift to Zeus and Hera on their wedding day, and its fruit shone pure gold. It was guarded by the Hesperides—four fearsome female warriors.

*Heracles would have to get past the Hesperides in order to take an apple.*

It would be impossible to defeat the Hesperides in a fight, but Heracles had a plan. He went to their father, Atlas, a Titan who was tasked with holding the weight of the sky on his shoulders. “Why not let me hold up the sky to give you a rest,” said Heracles, “and in exchange will you ask your daughters to give me a golden apple?” Excited to have a break, Atlas agreed.

When he returned, though, Atlas was reluctant to take the sky back. “I could take the apple to Eurystheus for you?” he asked.

Heracles saw this was a trick. “Okay,” he said, “but could you take the sky back for just a moment while I make a cushion for my head?” As soon as Atlas had put the apple on the ground and taken the sky back, Heracles grabbed the fruit and ran.

